A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



Don't Get Doxxed

A Plain-English Privacy Guide: How Small Clues Expose You, and How to Take Your Information Back

People-search sites • Security questions • SIM swaps
Locking down accounts • What to do if it happens

D.A. Williams

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Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund

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First edition, October 2026.

This book is for general education. It is not legal advice. Facts, figures, and web addresses were checked against the sources listed in the Notes at the back of the book as of October 2026. Websites, opt-out forms, and company policies change often. If something looks different when you try it, go to the company's official website yourself.

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how things usually go. They are not stories about real people.

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INTRODUCTION

One Small Detail

This guide started with a simple question: *"I remember a childhood birthday when my team won the big game. Could that be enough to dox me?"*

By itself, no. But it's a good question, because that is exactly how most people get exposed. Not by one big leak, but by a lot of small details that are harmless alone and dangerous together.

Doxxing means digging up someone's private information, like a home address, phone number, birth date, workplace, or family members, and using it or posting it to scare, shame, or harm them. It used to happen mostly to celebrities and activists. Today it can happen to anyone who argues with the wrong person online, leaves a bad review, runs a small business, or just has a public name.

Here's the uncomfortable truth: **a lot of your information is already out there.** Companies collect it, package it, and sell it, often for a few dollars. You can't erase all of it. But you can make it much harder to find,

much harder to use against you, and much less useful to a stranger.

This book is organized in plain steps:

- **Chapters 1 through 3** explain how small clues add up, where your information lives, and what someone can do with it.
- **Chapters 4 through 6** are the fix: getting off people-search sites, locking down your accounts and phone number, and changing a few posting habits.
- **Chapter 7** is what to do if it has already happened to you.

At the back, there's a one-page checklist, a list of free help, and Notes with sources for every fact.

None of this takes special skills. Most of it is free. Pick one step a day and you'll be ahead of most people within a week.

CHAPTER 1

How Small Clues Add Up

The birthday example

Say you post: *"Best birthday ever was the year my team won the championship."*

That sounds harmless. But championship games are played on a known date, and anyone can look it up in seconds. If the game fell on your birthday, a stranger now has the month and day. If your age is on your profile, or you mention your graduating class, or someone wished you "Happy 40th," they can work out the year too.

Now they have your full birth date. And a birth date is one of the most common things companies use to confirm "it's really you."

Even if the game was only *near* your birthday, the clue still narrows things down from 365 possible days to a handful. Add one or two more clues and the handful becomes one.

Three facts are often enough

In 2000, a Carnegie Mellon University researcher named Latanya Sweeney looked at U.S. Census data from 1990. She asked a simple question: how many people could be picked out of the crowd using just three facts?[1]

What she found:

- **87%** of the U.S. population (216 million of 248 million people) were likely unique based only on their **5-digit ZIP code, gender, and date of birth.**
- About **53%** were likely unique based on their **city or town, gender, and date of birth.**
- Even at the **county** level, about **18%** were likely unique.

In plain English: if someone knows your ZIP code, whether you're a man or a woman, and your birthday, there's a good chance they know exactly who you are. Those numbers come from 1990 Census data, but the point still holds: **it takes very few facts to single someone out.**

Clues people give away without thinking

Each of these is harmless alone. Together, they build a profile.

- Birthday posts, "Happy birthday to me," or a birthday-cake photo

- Your age, graduating class, or “I was 10 when…” stories
- Your hometown, high school, or the first street you lived on
- Your pet’s name, your kids’ names, your mother’s maiden name in a family post
- Your first car, favorite teacher, or favorite food
- Photos of your house, your street sign, your car’s license plate, or your view
- Check-ins at your gym, church, or favorite coffee shop at the same time every week
- Your workplace, uniform, or badge in a photo
- Your username, if you use the same one everywhere

Notice how many of those are also the answers to **security questions.** We’ll come back to that in Chapter 3.

CHAPTER 2

Where Your Information Already Lives

People-search sites and data brokers

A **data broker** is a company that collects information about people and sells it. A **people-search site** is the kind you can use yourself: type in a name and, for free or a small fee, get back possible addresses, phone numbers, ages, relatives, and past cities.

These companies pull from public records (like property and court records), marketing lists, and other sources. Many of them list people who have never heard of them.

Some of the best-known people-search sites in the United States are:

- Whitepages
- Spokeo
- BeenVerified
- Intelius, Instant Checkmate, and TruthFinder (all part of a company called PeopleConnect)
- PeopleFinders

- TruePeopleSearch
- FastPeopleSearch
- MyLife
- SearchPeopleFree
- US Search

There are hundreds more. California alone says its new deletion system reaches **over 600 registered data brokers.**[2]

Try this: Search your own name and city on two or three of these sites. Most people are surprised by what comes up. Then go to Chapter 4 to start removing it.

Courts are starting to push back

Some states have laws that protect certain people's home addresses. New Jersey's **Daniel's Law** protects the home addresses and unlisted phone numbers of judges, police officers, prosecutors, and others. According to a notice now posted at radaris.com, a New Jersey court entered a final judgment against the people-search site Radaris on August 27, 2026, for violating that law, and the radaris.com domain was transferred to one of the plaintiffs, a privacy company.[3] That is why Radaris's old opt-out page is not in this book.

Search engines

Even if you never visit a people-search site, their pages can show up when someone searches your name on Google. Google has a free tool called **Results about you** that can find search results showing your home address, phone number, or email address, and let you ask Google to remove them.[4] It's covered in Chapter 6.

Data breaches

Your information can also leak when a company that holds it gets hacked. You can't control that. What you can control is how much damage a leak can do, which is what Chapters 5 and 6 are about.

CHAPTER 3

What Someone Can Do With It

Most people who look you up are just curious. But here's what a person with bad intentions can do with the details from Chapters 1 and 2.

Guess your security questions

Many websites still ask security questions like "What was your first pet's name?" or "What city were you born in?" to let you back into an account.

Google studied hundreds of millions of these answers and found they are a weak lock:[6]

- With **one guess**, an attacker had a **19.7%** chance of guessing English-speaking users' answer to "What is your favorite food?" (The top answer was pizza.)
- With **ten guesses**, an attacker had a **39%** chance of guessing Korean-speaking users' city of birth.
- About **37%** of people gave false answers on purpose to be safer, but so many picked the *same* false answers that it made them *easier* to guess.

Google concluded that security questions are "neither secure nor reliable enough to be used as a standalone account recovery mechanism."[6] The fix, a random fake answer you store in a password manager, is in Chapter 5.

Take over your accounts

Your email account is the master key. If someone gets into it, they can click "Forgot password" on your bank, your social media, and everything else, and the reset links land in their hands. Guessed security questions, reused passwords, and stolen phone numbers are the most common ways in.

Steal your phone number (SIM swap)

In a **SIM swap**, a criminal convinces your phone company to move your number to a phone *they* control. They often do it by pretending to be you, using the personal details they found, or by bribing or tricking a phone company employee. Once they have your number, the text-message login codes for your bank, email, and crypto accounts go to them.[7]

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) received **1,611** SIM swap complaints in 2021, with losses of more than **$68 million.** From 2018 through 2020 combined, it had received only 320.[7]

A similar trick, **port-out fraud,** moves your number to a different phone company.[8] Chapter 5 shows how to lock your number down.

Open accounts in your name (identity theft)

With your name, birth date, and address, and especially your Social Security number, a thief can try to open credit cards, loans, or phone accounts in your name. A credit freeze stops most of this cold. It's free, and it's covered briefly in Chapter 6.

Harass, threaten, or show up

This is the part that makes doxxing frightening. A home address posted online can lead to unwanted mail, packages, calls, people showing up at your door, or contact with your employer or family. Chapter 7 covers what to do if that happens.

CHAPTER 4

Getting Off People-Search Sites

This takes an afternoon. It's free. And it removes the easiest shortcut a stranger has to your front door.

Before you start

- **Use a separate email address** just for opt-outs, so your main email isn't handed to more companies. A free email account works fine.
- **Keep a simple list:** site name, date you submitted, and whether you got a confirmation.
- **Don't pay.** Every site listed below offers a free opt-out. If a site tries to charge you to remove your own listing, stop and look for its free privacy or opt-out link at the bottom of the page.
- **Most sites will email you a confirmation link.** Your request usually isn't finished until you click it.
- **Many sites ask for the web address of your listing.** Search for yourself on the site first, open your listing, and copy the address from your browser's address bar.

Free opt-out pages

These were checked in October 2026. Type the address into your browser, or use the clickable links in the Notes.

- **Whitepages:** whitepages.com/suppression-requests. Paste in the link to your listing.[21]
- **Spokeo:** spokeo.com/optout. Paste in the link to your listing.[22]
- **Intelius, Instant Checkmate, and TruthFinder:** these all send you to the **PeopleConnect Suppression Center** at suppression.peopleconnect.us. It starts with your email address and lets you manage your listing across the people-search sites PeopleConnect owns.[23]
- **BeenVerified:** beenverified.com/app/optout/search.[24]
- **PeopleFinders:** peoplefinders.com/opt-out.[25]
- **TruePeopleSearch:** truepeoplesearch.com/removal.[26]
- **FastPeopleSearch:** fastpeoplesearch.com/removal.[27]
- **MyLife:** mylife.com/privacyrequest.[28]
- **SearchPeopleFree:** searchpeoplefree.com/opt-out.[29]
- **US Search:** ussearch.com/opt-out/submit.[30]

> **REMEMBER:** These sites keep collecting new records. Search for yourself again every few months, and repeat any opt-out where your listing has come back.

If you live in California

California residents can use a free state tool called **DROP** (Delete Request and Opt-out Platform) at **privacy.ca.gov/drop**. One request goes to over 600 registered data brokers. Brokers had to start processing requests on August 1, 2026, and must check DROP again at least every 45 days, so it keeps working over time. It can take up to 90 days to see results.[2]

If you don't live in California, check your own state attorney general's website. Privacy laws are changing in many states.

What about paid removal services?

Some companies will do these opt-outs for you for a yearly fee. That can save time, but nothing they do is something you can't do yourself for free with the list above. If you use one, read exactly which sites it covers.

CHAPTER 5

Locking Down Your Accounts and Your Phone Number

If Chapter 4 makes you harder to find, this chapter makes you harder to *break into*, even when someone already knows a lot about you.

Step 1: Use a password manager

A password manager is an app that creates and remembers a different strong password for every account. You only need to remember one master password. The U.S. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) recommends using one for all your passwords, and protecting it with a long, unique passphrase.[9]

Many phones and browsers have one built in, and there are free and paid options from other companies.

Step 2: Give fake answers to security questions, and save them

Never give a real answer to a security question. A real answer can be guessed or looked up.

But don't use a cute fake answer either, like "pizza" or "none of your business." As Chapter 3 showed, lots of people pick the same fake answers.

Do this instead:

- Make each answer random nonsense, like *Gravel-Teapot-Ninety*.
- Save it in your password manager, in the notes for that account.
- Use a different answer for every site.

Step 3: Turn on two-step login, the right way

Two-step login (also called two-factor or multi-factor authentication) means you need a second thing besides your password to log in.

Not all second steps are equal. CISA's advice, from strongest to weakest:[9]

1. **Passkeys or hardware security keys.** These are the strongest because they can't be phished.
2. **An authenticator app** that shows a six-digit code that changes every 30 seconds. CISA names free apps like Google Authenticator and Microsoft Authenticator.
3. **Text message (SMS) codes.** CISA says plainly: "Do not use SMS as a second factor for authentication." Text messages aren't encrypted, and a SIM swap sends them straight to the thief.

Important: after you set up an authenticator app or a passkey, go back and **turn off** the text-message option. CISA warns that adding an app does not automatically remove SMS, and the old text option can be used as a weak back door.[9]

Some services will still send a text during account recovery no matter what. That's another reason to protect your phone number.

Start with these accounts: your main email, your bank and credit cards, your phone company account, your password manager, and your social media.

Step 4: Lock your phone number

Your phone company account is where SIM swaps happen. Protect it.

- **Set a PIN or passcode on your phone company account.** CISA calls this a "Telco PIN." It's needed for big changes like moving your number to another phone company.[9] Don't use your birthday or the last four digits of your Social Security number.
- **Turn on the free number-lock feature** if your carrier has one. As of October 2026:
  - **T-Mobile** offers free **SIM Protection** (blocks moving your number to a new SIM card) and **Port Out Protection** (blocks transferring your line to another carrier). Port Out Protection has to be turned on for each line separately.[10]

    - **Verizon** offers **SIM Protection** and **Number Lock**, managed in your My Verizon account.[11]
    - **AT&T** offers **Wireless Account Lock**, managed in the myAT&T app.[12]
    - Other carriers: call the number on your bill or check your account settings and ask about a port-out PIN or account lock.

- **Remember to turn the lock off** when you really do want to switch phones or carriers, then turn it back on.

Since 2023, federal rules require wireless companies to use secure ways to confirm it's really you before moving your number to a new phone or carrier, and to notify you right away when someone asks to do that.[8] **If you ever get a text or email about a SIM change or number transfer you didn't ask for, call your carrier immediately** using the number on your bill or the carrier's official website.

CHAPTER 6

Stop Feeding the Machine

Think before you post

You don't have to quit social media. Just stop handing out the answers.

- **Don't post your birthday,** your age, or your graduating year. If friends post "Happy birthday," that's fine, but skip the "40 years ago today" details.
- **Skip the "get to know me" quizzes and games** that ask your first pet, first car, first street, high school mascot, or mother's maiden name. Those are the same questions banks and websites use to verify you.
- **Don't show your house number, street sign, license plate, or work badge** in photos.
- **Post trips after you get home,** not while your house is empty.
- **Set your profiles to friends-only** where you can, and hide your friends list, birthday, and hometown.

Strip location data from photos

Phones can save the exact location where a photo was taken inside the photo file.

- **iPhone:** when you share a photo from the Photos app, tap **Options** and turn off **Location** before sending. To stop the camera from saving locations in the first place, go to **Settings** > **Privacy & Security** > **Location Services** > **Camera** and choose **Never.**[13]
- **Android:** look in your camera app's settings for a location or GPS tag option and turn it off. The wording is different on different phone brands.

Clean up old posts

Scroll back through your old public posts and photos, especially from years ago, before you thought about privacy. Delete or hide anything that shows your address, birth date, kids' schools, or the answers to common security questions.

Keep business and personal separate

If you run a business, write, make videos, or sell anything online, give the public a **separate business email and phone number.** Many free services can give you a second phone number. Keep your personal email (the one tied to your bank and password resets) private. That way, the email you publish can't be used to reset your important accounts.

Use Google's "Results about you"

Go to **myactivity.google.com/results-about-you** while signed in to your Google account.[5]

- Enter your name and the contact information you want to watch for, like your home address, phone number, and email.
- Google will check its search results and can notify you when it finds new ones.
- You can ask Google to remove results that show your personal contact information.

Two things to know:[4]

- Google won't remove some results it considers valuable to the public, like government, school, or news websites.
- Removing a result from Google **doesn't delete the page.** The information is still on the original website. That's why you also do the opt-outs in Chapter 4.

Freeze your credit (short version)

A **credit freeze** stops anyone, including a thief using your information, from opening new credit in your name. It's **free** to place and free to lift, and it doesn't hurt your credit score.[14] Free freezes became a right nationwide under a federal law, the Economic Growth, Regulatory Relief, and Consumer Protection Act, starting **September 21, 2018.**[15]

You have to freeze at **all three** credit bureaus:

- **Equifax:** equifax.com/personal/credit-report-services/credit-freeze[16]
- **Experian:** experian.com/help/credit-freeze[17]
- **TransUnion:** transunion.com/credit-freeze[18]

When you need to apply for credit, you can lift the freeze temporarily. The companion guide in this series, *After a Scam*, covers freezes, fraud alerts, and free weekly credit reports in more detail.

Optional extra freezes: Two smaller reporting companies also offer free freezes:

- **ChexSystems,** used by many banks when you open a checking or savings account: chexsystems.com/security-freeze/place-freeze.[19]
- **NCTUE,** a database used for phone, cable, and utility accounts: nctueconsumerportal.com, or call 1-866-349-5355.[20]

CHAPTER 7

If You've Been Doxxed

If someone has posted your private information or is using it against you, here's what to do, in order.

> **IMPORTANT:** If you're in danger right now, or someone has threatened to hurt you, call 911.

Step 1: Document everything

Before anything gets deleted, save proof.

- Take screenshots that show the post, the account name, and the date.
- Copy the web address of each post or page.
- Save threatening messages, emails, voicemails, and call logs.
- Write down a simple timeline: what happened, when, and who.

Don't argue with the person or respond to them. It rarely helps and can make things worse.

Step 2: Report it to the platform

Major platforms have rules against posting people's private information.

- **X** prohibits sharing other people's private information, like home addresses and phone numbers, and says it may act against home addresses being shared even if they're publicly available elsewhere, because of the risk of physical harm.[31]
- **Meta** (Facebook and Instagram) prohibits sharing private information that could lead to physical or financial harm, including residential and financial information.[32]

Use the platform's built-in **Report** button on the post. Choose the option about private or personal information.

Step 3: Get it out of search results

Use Google's **Results about you** tool (Chapter 6) to request removal of search results that show your contact information.[4] Then do the people-search opt-outs in Chapter 4, since those sites are often where doxxers get the information in the first place.

Step 4: Lock everything down, fast

Do Chapter 5 right away: change your email password first, turn on an authenticator app, turn off text-message

codes, and call your phone company to add a PIN and number lock.

Step 5: Report it to the authorities

- **Local police:** if there are threats, stalking, or anyone shows up at your home. Bring your screenshots and timeline. Ask for a copy of the report.
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center: ic3.gov** takes reports of crimes committed online.[33]
- **If someone used your information to open accounts or commit fraud:** go to **IdentityTheft.gov**, the FTC's official site, for a free identity theft report and a personal recovery plan.[34] You can also report scams and fraud at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**.[35]
- **If money was taken:** see the companion guide *After a Scam* for step-by-step recovery.

Step 6: Tell the people who need to know

- **Family and housemates,** so they don't confirm anything to strangers who call or show up.
- **Your employer,** if your workplace was posted, so front desk and security staff know.
- **Your bank,** if financial information was exposed.

Being doxxed is stressful and frightening. It isn't your fault. Lean on people you trust, and take it one step at a time.

APPENDIX

The One-Page Don't Get Doxxed Checklist

Print this page. Free to copy and share.

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: Small clues add up. Stop posting the answers to your security questions.

Get off people-search sites

- ☐ Search your name and city on 2 or 3 people-search sites.
- ☐ Opt out: Whitepages, Spokeo, PeopleConnect (Intelius, Instant Checkmate, TruthFinder), BeenVerified, PeopleFinders, TruePeopleSearch, FastPeopleSearch, MyLife, SearchPeopleFree, US Search.
- ☐ Click every confirmation email.
- ☐ California resident? Use DROP at privacy.ca.gov/drop.
- ☐ Set up Google "Results about you."
- ☐ Set a reminder to search yourself again in 3 months.

Lock down your accounts

- ☐ Use a password manager.
- ☐ Random fake answers to security questions, saved in the manager.
- ☐ Authenticator app or passkey on email, bank, phone company, and social media.
- ☐ Turn off text-message (SMS) codes after setting up the app.
- ☐ Add a PIN to your phone company account.
- ☐ Turn on your carrier's free SIM or number lock.

Stop feeding the machine

- ☐ No birthday, age, pet, school, or first-car posts. Skip "get to know me" quizzes.
- ☐ Turn off photo location tags.
- ☐ Clean up old public posts.
- ☐ Separate business email and phone from personal.
- ☐ Freeze credit at Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion (free).

If you've been doxxed: Danger? Call 911. Screenshot everything. Report to the platform. Lock down accounts. Report to police and **ic3.gov**. Identity misused? **IdentityTheft.gov**.

My opt-out log: Site _____ Date _____ Confirmed? ___ Recheck _____

From Don't Get Doxxed *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes. Not legal advice.*

RESOURCES

Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Websites and phone numbers can change. Look up any organization's official website yourself.

This book is not legal advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.

To report

- **Emergency or threats of violence:** 911, or your local police.
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov.[33]
- **Identity theft:** IdentityTheft.gov.[34]
- **Scams and fraud:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov.[35]
- **Posts sharing your private information:** use the Report button on the post. X and Meta both have rules against it.[31] [32]

To remove your information

- **People-search opt-outs:** the list in Chapter 4.

- **Google "Results about you":** myactivity.google.com/results-about-you.[5]
- **California DROP:** privacy.ca.gov/drop.[2]

To protect your accounts and credit

- **CISA's mobile security guidance** (passkeys, authenticator apps, telco PIN): search "CISA Mobile Communications Best Practice Guidance."[9]
- **Credit freezes:** Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion (links in the Notes).[16] [17] [18]
- **Bank account freeze:** ChexSystems.[19]
- **Phone and utility freeze:** NCTUE, 1-866-349-5355.[20]

Companion guides

- **Free guides by D.A. Williams:** *Protect Your Parents*, *After a Scam*, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, and *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, free wherever you found this book.
- **More from Red Pills of Freedom:** straight facts, no spin, at redpillsoffreedom.com. If this guide helped, pass it on to someone who posts their birthday every year.

Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Some people-search and company websites block automated checks; each address below was confirmed to load in a regular web browser or to redirect to the company's own opt-out page. Opt-out forms change often. If an address stops working, go to the site's home page and look for a "Privacy," "Opt Out," or "Do Not Sell My Personal Information" link at the bottom.

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2. California Privacy Protection Agency, "Delete Request and Opt-out Platform (DROP)," privacy.ca.gov, accessed October 2026 (free; for California residents; one request to over 600 registered data brokers; brokers begin processing August 1, 2026, and must access DROP at least every 45 days; up to 90 days for status updates). https://privacy.ca.gov/drop/
3. Notice posted at radaris.com, "This Domain Has Been Transferred by Court Order," regarding *Atlas Data Privacy Corporation, et al. v. Radaris.com, et al.*, Superior Court of New Jersey, Law Division, Middlesex County, Docket No. MID-L-000847-24 (final judgment by default entered August 27, 2026, under N.J.S.A. § 56:8-166.1, "Daniel's Law"), accessed October 2026. https://radaris.com/control/privacy

4. Google Search Help, “Find and remove personal info in Google Search results,” accessed October 2026 (types of contact information covered; notifications; Google may deny removal for government, educational, and news websites; removal from Google does not remove the information from the source website). https://support.google.com/websearch/answer/12719076

5. Google, “Results about you” (sign-in required), accessed October 2026. https://myactivity.google.com/results-about-you

6. Elie Bursztein and Ilan Caron, “New Research: Some Tough Questions for ‘Security Questions’,” Google Online Security Blog, May 21, 2015, summarizing Joseph Bonneau et al., “Secrets, Lies, and Account Recovery: Lessons from the Use of Personal Knowledge Questions at Google,” WWW 2015. https://security.googleblog.com/2015/05/new-research-some-tough-questions-for.html Paper: https://static.googleusercontent.com/media/research.google.com/en/us/pubs/archive/43783.pdf

7. Federal Bureau of Investigation, Internet Crime Complaint Center, “Criminals Increasing SIM Swap Schemes to Steal Millions of Dollars from US Public,” Public Service Announcement I-020822-PSA, February 8, 2022 (320 complaints and about $12 million in adjusted losses from January 2018 to December 2020; 1,611 complaints and more than $68 million in 2021; methods include social engineering, insider threat, and phishing). https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2022/PSA220208

8. Federal Communications Commission, “Protecting Consumers from SIM-Swap and Port-Out Fraud,” Report and Order FCC 23-95, adopted November 15, 2023, published in the Federal Register December 8, 2023 (wireless providers must use secure methods to authenticate customers before a SIM change or port-out, and must immediately notify customers of SIM change and port-out requests). https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/12/08/2023-26338/protecting-consumers-from-sim-swap-and-port-out-fraud

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